

confuse who gets what, but the kids are not likely to forget. They will hold you and their siblings responsible for being shorted. False promises often lead to discord and conflicts.

5. Never give cash or other significant gifts to your adult children as part of a negotiation strategy.

Give because of love, even obligation and kindness. Adult children often lose their respect and love for parents who submit to high-pressure negotiating tactics. Coercion of this type is often the product of the manner in which parents negotiate with their young children. Even preteens are taught the benefits of “Johnny got a bike so I should get a wagon.” Johnny and his brother should receive symbols of love and kindness but, instead, they learn that Mom and Dad must be pushed, squeezed, and coerced into giving. The boys may begin to view each other as adversaries.

Often parents perpetuate conflicts even among their adult children. Have you ever told one of your children or grandchildren something like the following:

We helped your brother remodel his house/sent his kids to private school/paid his health insurance. We want you to have a few extra dollars. Would \$5,000 be all right?

What’s wrong with such offers? Often those on the receiving end view them as signs of guilt or appeasement on the part of their parents.

6. Stay out of your adult children’s family matters.

Please note, parents, that your vision of the ideal lifestyle may be diametrically opposed to that of your adult son or daughter, as well as that of your son-in-law or daughter-in-law. Adult children resent interference from their parents. Let them run their own lives; ask permission even to give advice. Ask permission also when contemplating giving significant gifts to your children.